

Write on

In an ongoing bid to make its devices more accessible to the masses, the operating system subsidiary of handheld maker Palm, PalmSource, announced that it will use a handwriting recognition system in the new Palm devices. Dubbed Graffiti2, the system is based on Jot and is aimed at users who feel the old Graffiti system to be too idiosyncratic

for easy use. Keyboards for handhelds are finding a greater number of consumers and newer devices from Sony, Sharp and Handspring now come with a keyboard.

Graffiti 2 supports natural handwriting as input

Michael Higashi, a director of marketing at PalmSource,

acknowledged the trend, but saw no conflict between Graffiti and traditional input systems. Short bits of information favour Jot, while more involved tasks such as writing e-mail are better done with keyboards.

Graffiti2 is already available to licensees such as Sony and Kyocera and will be embedded into versions 5.2 and 4.1.2 of the Palm OS. It will be up to the licensees as to when they begin shipping devices that come with Graffiti 2 out of the box.

snapshot

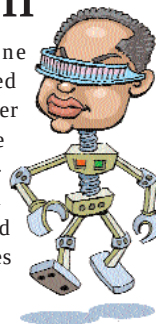
1.5 million GameCubes, 1.4 million Xbox and 6 million PlayStation 2 sold in Europe in 2002

Source: ScreenDigest & Nintendo

Eye can walk again

Present days robots require visual cues in the form of reflective tapes or barcodes strategically placed to let them do rudimentary tasks like find their way around homes or offices. To alleviate this problem, a Carnegie Mellon University professor, Hans Moravec, has developed a set of digital cameras that will give its owners a stereoscopic vision. Based on the relative distance of the same object within the two different cameras, the designed system will calculate the distance between the said object and the robot. If

an object in one camera is blocked from the other camera, or if the eyeballs are presented with a blank wall devoid of any features that aid in triangulation, Moravec's 3D grid setup comes to the rescue. The grid forms the brain behind the eyes and is made up of 32 million digital cells that are used to help fill incomplete or misleading data by means of statistical analysis and extrapolations.



Biometrics Benchched for Super Bowl

In the Super Bowl 2003 in San Diego, authorities are sidelining controversial biometric security systems in favour of hundreds of human agents. The facial scan technology weeded 19 offenders from over 1,00,000 people in the 2001 Super Bowl. The



computer matches facial scans taken from cameras located at strategic points, against databases of known offenders. There are too many false alarms if the threshold level is low and no matches if the threshold levels are maintained high enough.

quoteworthy

"The import of those products would be an act of piracy. The industry is regretful that these absolutely piratical products are being released"

Neil Turkewitz, Executive Vice President International of the RIAA, strongly advocating copyright protection

"There is no business justification; I did it because people should have the choice to run the software they want on the hardware of their choice...I don't think when you buy a car, they should tell you what brand of gas to put in it."

Michael Robertson, CEO of Lindows, upon revealing himself as the anonymous donor of \$200,000 in prize money in a contest to translate Linux to Xbox

tomorrow's technology

See the light!

First the incandescent bulb, then fluorescent lights, and now dispel the darkness with light-emitting diodes (LEDs). In LED territory, the sickly green glow is a thing of the past—today's LEDs are bright white, use 10 per cent less power than incandescent bulbs but generate the same apparent illumination with negligible heat, and can last up to 20 years.

Already, cities around the

world are replacing incandescent traffic lights with arrays of LEDs. Besides this, LEDs are also being used in bicycle lights and camping equipment. Two products from Princeton Tec (www.princeton-tec.com) are already available—the Attitude with three ultra-bright white LEDs and 150 hours of burn time costs about Rs 1,000, while the Impact II with a single LED and 75 hours of burn time costs about

Rs 1,500. Both measure 5 inches long, use four AAA batteries and work underwater up to a depth of 500 feet.

For the outdoors types, Petzl (www.petzl.com), offers a variety of LED headlamps. In the meantime, Boston-based Colour Kinetics (www.colourkinetics.com) is providing a more affordable product line, Sauce, that makes available LED night lights and bulb replacements.